

THE AXE EFFECT

In a desperate attempt to keep Brahmin votes in its fold, BJP venerates the mythical warrior-sage Parashuram

■ By Ambresh Mishra

Lord Ram is passé. Lord Parashuram is a *la mode* as the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party's new political mascot in Madhya Pradesh. And Janapav, an obscure hillock in Indore district believed to be the birthplace of the mythical axe-wielding warrior-sage, is the party's new Ayodhya. After Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan announced on May 8, a day after Parashuram Jayanti, that the spot will be developed into a full-fledged pilgrimage centre with a grant of Rs 11 crore, the party hopes that its from here that its journey to a repeat victory in the state would start.

From former chief minister Digvijay Singh's divisive Dalit agenda just five years back, social engineering has taken a U-turn in Madhya Pradesh. As political parties prepare for their Assembly election campaigns due later this year, the scales have tipped the Brahmin way. As recent developments show, the community has rarely had it so good in state politics since 1989 when the last Brahmin chief minister, the late Shyamacharan Shukla was in office.

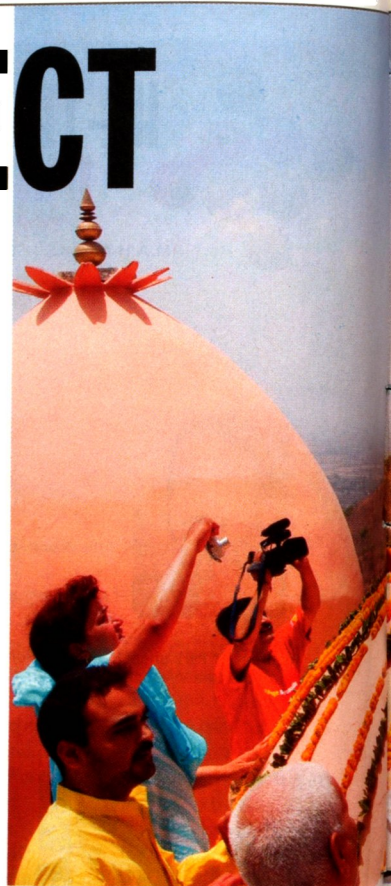
For good measure, Chauhan also declared Parashuram Jayanti as an optional holiday on his Janapav sojourn and then upgraded it to a regular government holiday. The party has also formed a three-member committee comprising Water Resources Minister and former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's nephew Anup Mishra, party's campaign committee head Anil Madhav Dave and vice-chairman of the state-level National Integration Committee Ramesh

OUTSIDER: Pachouri's opponents are mostly within the Congress

Sharma to oversee the development of the pilgrimage centre.

With BJP's efforts to woo Brahmin voters and repeat its Uttar Pradesh success in Madhya Pradesh, BJP had been toying with the idea for a long time. However, the decision to devote serious thought to focus on the community's political mindscape was taken after an internal survey by the party showed that Brahmin voters could switch their two-decade-old loyalty from BJP to either BSP or the Congress.

Fearing mass exodus of Brahmin community to BSP, the Congress was the first to make a move on luring the community by appointing Suresh Pachouri as PCC president in March this year. Then BJP made its intentions clear by declaring its first 71-strong list of candidates for the coming Assembly polls more than six months in advance, with Brahmins getting the largest



PANKAJ TIWARI



share of tickets.

Now BJP has started wooing Brahmins with the Parashuram move. Last week, the party's Brahmin leaders even held a function at the chief minister's house to felicitate Chauhan for giving Lord Parashuram—one of the few Brahmin members of the Hindu pantheon—his due. Says the chief minister, "Religion has deep roots in our society. Lord Parashuram is a widely revered God. It is our effort to recognise the religious sensitivities of everyone."

At first glance, the move on part of each political party appears to be sound following the trend in Uttar Pradesh. But closer examination reveals there are many differentiators. One of them being sheer numbers. In Madhya Pradesh, Brahmin votes tilt the balance one way or the other in some urban constituencies and in

With an eye on the Brahmin vote, the Congress appointed Pachouri as PCC chief.